

CREATIVE PARTNERS
(left to right) Architects and partners Anand Sharma, Goonmeet Singh Chauhan and Anoj Tevatia at their Delhi office; Delhi High Court (below left); WoCO One, Gurgaon (below right)

In the noisy, ego-driven colosseum of Indian architecture, Design Forum International (DFI) has spent three decades performing a rare, near-miraculous trick. They have effortlessly balanced the unhinged commercial appetite of luxury housing and mega-malls with the stoic, red-tape-wrapped reality of massive civic infrastructure. Founded by Anand Sharma, Anoj Tevatia and Goonmeet Singh Chauhan, three IIT Kharagpur graduates who kicked off their practice in 1995 with zero built portfolio, the firm has shaped how modern India lives, shops and commutes.

To look at DFI today is to look at a machine handling 500 active projects simultaneously, spanning one head office in Delhi and three micro-offices across Chennai, Hyderabad and Bangalore. But to understand how they got here, one has to understand how they masterfully hijacked the corporate landscape in 1995. Fresh out of college, armed with nothing but intense ambition and a borrowed Maruti 800, the trio christened themselves 'TCS' (Tevatia Chauhan and Sharma). Their very first pitch for a local property dealer in Janakpuri was pure theatre. "We were straight out of college, decking ourselves with the nice shoes, bell-bottom trousers, formal things and cologne," recalls Tevatia. They hired a driver to hold a physical model out of the car door. The client's friends were so thoroughly zapped that DFI closed the deal right there in the driveway. "Our college expenses per month were not more than ₹1,500 and we cracked



